



fficiating at a Wedding

Part 1: A Step-By-Step Guide



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NOTE: For a thorough, detailed analysis of the marriage procedure, it is recommended to purchase the author's book, *Seder Kiddushin Venissuin*, published by Kehot. The book also includes an abridged, concise guide for the mesader kiddushin (in Hebrew and English); questionnaires for the bride and groom; the nusach of the various types of kesubos (including removable templates that can be photocopied as needed) and the words that are filled in; and more.

DISCLAIMER: Reading this article does not qualify the reader to serve as a mesader kiddushin. It is meant to assist those who have studied the necessary halachos, namely, the relevant halachos of yuchsin and kiddushin in *Even Ha'Ezer*. See sidebar on p. 49 for more on the prerequisites necessary to be a mesader kiddushin.



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INTRODUCTION

Being approached with a request to be mesader kiddushin is a great zechus, as well as a tremendous achrayus. We have the ability to set up the new couple on the path to a happy, joyous life, one built on the foundations of Torah and mitzvos.

Due to the length of this topic, it will be addressed in two parts. The first installment, presented in this issue, will include a step-by-step guide of the various stages of the ceremony, as well as a list of questions and answers relating to the wedding ceremony. The second installment, to be presented in a future issue b'ezras Hashem, will examine in greater details the laws of yuchsin, kesubah, and the kashrus of the witnesses, and will also feature additional questions and answers about common situations and mishaps that may occur during the wedding procedure.

[Editor's note: To submit a question to be included in the next installment, please email editor@compassmagazine.org.]

Basics of a Jewish Marriage

The first area that must be clarified is the halachic basics of marriage. A Jewish marriage consists of two parts: kiddushin, also known as eirusin, and nissuin. Kiddushin is the act of acquiring a wife, causing her to “belong” to the husband and creating the issur of eishes ish, in which she is now forbidden to marry anyone else (unless the first marriage terminates through death or divorce). Nissuin refers to the act of the groom bringing the bride into his domain (known as “entering the chupah”), which consummates the husband-wife relationship and initiates the rights and responsibilities of both parties toward each other.¹

In the time of Chazal, these two steps were performed at two distinct times, separated by an extensive time period between the two. However, nowadays it is customary to perform one stage immediately after the other during the marriage ceremony.

How are these two steps accomplished?

Kiddushin: The groom gives his bride an item worth a perutah in front of two kosher witnesses and states verbally that he is betrothing her with this act. The kiddushin is realized when the bride willingly accepts the item from the groom.

Nissuin: The Mishnah states that nissuin is accomplished when the bride leaves her father's home and enters her husband's domain.² Nowadays, when the nissuin takes place together with the kiddushin, it is accomplished through a specific act that demonstrates that the groom is bringing the bride into his domain. Since there are various approaches in Rishonim as to how this is done,³ it has become customary to incorporate a number of acts into the marriage ceremony, with each one constituting the “entering the chupah” according to one approach. Hence, the groom covers the bride's face with a veil (the badekenish),⁴ the bride and groom stand together under the chupah, and they subsequently both enter a room and spend some time there together alone (the yichud room).⁵

In addition to the acts that accomplish these two steps, the marriage ceremony includes a host of rituals and customs, most of which are sourced in the Gemara and Poskim. Many of them are done to enhance and beautify the marriage procedure and instill an awesomeness of this momentous occasion.

¹ *Rambam, Ishus* 1:1–3, 10:1.

² *Kesubos* 48b.

³ See *Shulchan Aruch, Even Ha'ezer* 55:1.

⁴ According to this opinion, the word chupah means covering (*Ezer Mikodesh* 55:1).

⁵ *Bach, Even Ha'ezer* 61.

Step-By-Step Guide

Tena'im



The shtar tena'im is a document delineating the commitment of the bride and groom to get married and the additional obligations accepted by them and their parents.⁶

The tena'im are prepared on the day of the wedding.⁷ Fill out the names of the representatives of the groom and bride (namely, their fathers or shushvinim), the guarantors, and the groom and bride. Next, in the presence of two kosher witnesses, a kinyan sudar is made by each of the representatives, the guarantors, the groom, and the bride (see below, p. 50). (Often, the bride is not present; in such a case, her father or shushvin should make a kinyan on her behalf.)

After the kinyanim have been made, fill out the word *vekanina*,⁸ the date, and the location. Finally, two kosher witnesses sign the document, each writing his name, his father's name, and the word *ed*.⁹ Before signing, the witnesses should read the document (or its content should be repeated to them).

Two copies of the shtar tena'im should be prepared, one for the parents/shushvinim of the groom and one for the parents/shushvinim of the bride.

Note: A list of what makes a witness unfit will appear in the second installment, *b'ezras Hashem*.

Kesubah



The kesubah is a document enumerating the marital obligations of the husband

⁶ For a detailed analysis of the shtar tena'im and its history, see *Tena'im Vort Eirusin Venissuin* (authored by Rabbi Sholom Ber Levine and published by Kehot).

⁷ See *Igros Kodesh* vol. 7, p. 19.

⁸ Since the word *vekanina* means "we have made a kinyan," it can only be written after the kinyanim are made.

⁹ It is preferable to use witnesses who can sign their names in Hebrew. If this is not possible, they may sign their Hebrew names in English letters (e.g., "Reuven ben Yaakov *ed*").

toward his wife. The kesubah must be kept in a safe place at all times. If it is misplaced, relations are forbidden until it is replaced¹⁰ and a rov should be contacted immediately.

On the day of the wedding (during the daytime hours¹¹), prepare the kesubah. Fill out the date, location, names, amounts, and the details relating to the bride's status. Explain the content of the kesubah to the groom and witnesses. In the presence of two kosher witnesses, the groom makes a kinyan sudar (see below, p. 50). Next, fill out the word *vekanina*. Two kosher witnesses then sign, each writing his name, his father's name, and the word *ed*.

Note: Additional details relating to the writing of the kesubah will appear in the second installment, *b'ezras Hashem*.

¹⁰ *Shulchan Aruch, Even Ha'ezer* 66:3.

¹¹ See *Toras Menachem* vol. 10, p. 199.



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Kabbalas Panim



Two receptions are made, one for the groom and another for the bride.¹² During the kabbalas panim, someone is honored to read the tena'im, after which a china or porcelain plate is broken (to commemorate the destruction of Yerushalayim) by the mothers of the bride and groom or by the bride's shushvinim.¹³ If possible, the groom (or someone else) should review the maamar Lechah Dodi.¹⁴

Badekenish



The groom, accompanied by his shushvinim, approaches the bride and covers her face with a veil. The bride remains with her face covered until after the chupah.

According to one opinion in Rishonim, this is how nissuin is accomplished (see above, p. 40). Additionally, by having her face covered, the bride demonstrates that the value of the item she will receive from the groom for kiddushin is of no consequence to her.¹⁵

According to Chabad custom, during the badekenish the Alter Rebbe's niggun of Daled Bavos is sung/played.¹⁶

After the badekenish, it is customary for the parents and grandparents to bless the bride.

Chupah Preparations



Assisted by his shushvinim, the groom puts on a kittel. The kittel resembles burial shrouds, arousing the groom to teshuvah,¹⁷ and is white, symbolizing that all his sins are forgiven.¹⁸

According to Chabad custom, the groom dons a coat above the kittel.¹⁹ According to one custom, the parents take this opportunity to bless the groom.

It is customary to untie all knots in the clothing of the bride and groom (such as shoelaces and the groom's tie). It is also customary to remove any money, jewelry, and other costly items from the groom's pockets (and hands), and to remove any silver cufflinks, pins, etc. from his clothing.²⁰

12 *Shulchan Ha'ezer* vol. 2, p. 17b.

13 *Malbushei Yom Tov* to Levush, *Orach Chaim* 560.

14 See *Sefer Haminhagim* p. 75 and *Toras Menachem* vol. 8, pp. 218-220.

15 *Rama, Even Ha'ezer* 31:2.

16 *Sefer Haminhagim* p. 76.

17 *Kitzur Shulchan Aruch* 147:4.

18 *Mateh Moshe, Hachnasas Kallah* 1:2.

19 *Igros Kodesh* vol. 5, p. 87.

20 *Sefer Haminhagim* p. 76. See *Shulchan Ha'ezer* (vol. 2, p. 31c), who states that untying knots is done to ward off potential forces of sorcery, and *ibid.* (p. 136b), that the empty pockets serve as a reminder that a person cannot take his belongings with him to the next world.

Entering the Chupah



The groom enters the chupah accompanied by his shushvinim, who carry candles as a sign of joy.²¹ The groom stands under the chupah, facing east.²² Next, the bride approaches the chupah, accompanied by her shushvinim. According to one custom, as the bride approaches the chupah, the groom's shushvinim take a few steps toward her to greet her. (For more on the subject of shushvinim, see below, p. 50.)

By entering first, the groom demonstrates that he is bringing the bride into his domain. Additionally, this demonstrates that the bride is willingly approaching the groom to accept the kiddushin.²³

According to Chabad custom, when the groom and bride approach the chupah and during the seven circuits, the Alter Rebbe's niggun of Daled Bavos is sung/played.²⁴

Circling the Groom



The bride circles the groom seven times counterclockwise.²⁵ (See sidebar on p. 52 for a beautiful explanation from the Rebbe on this custom.²⁶) According to Chabad custom, the shushvinim—both men and women—join the bride in circling the groom.²⁷ Upon concluding the seven circuits, the bride stands to the right of the groom.²⁸

Kibbudim



Someone is honored to sing Baruch Haba and Mi Adir. It is also customary to honor someone with reading the Rebbe's letter. Some also honor a kohen to bless the couple with Birchas Kohanim.

Designating Witnesses



Call upon two kosher witnesses to witness the kiddushin.²⁹

21 See *Maharil, Hilchos Nissuin*, and *Mateh Moshe, Hachnasas Kallah* 1:2.

22 See *Shulchan Ha'ezer* vol. 2, p. 32c-d.

23 *Likkutei Mahariach, Seder Nissuin*.

24 See *Sefer Haminhagim* p. 76.

25 Seven times—*Kitzur Shulchan Aruch* 147:5. Counterclockwise—see *Seder Kiddushin Venissuin* p. 44, fn. 12.

26 See also *Toras Menachem* vol. 3, pp. 293-294.

27 *Sefer Haminhagim* p. 76.

28 This is hinted in the passuk של למיך נצבה, "a queen stands to your right" (*Tehillim* 45:10), the last letters of which form the word נלה (*Rokeiach*, quoted in *Ba'er Heitev, Even Ha'ezer* 61:7).

29 Seemingly, the people viewing the ceremony can automatically serve as witnesses. However, since the onlookers include relatives and other unfit witnesses, this may invalidate the testimony—even of those qualified to serve as witnesses. It is therefore recommended to single out two kosher witnesses and call them up to watch the kiddushin, so

Note: A list of what makes a witness unfit will appear in the second installment, *b'e'zras Hashem*.

Birchas Eirusin



The kiddushin is preceded by birchas eirusin, which some understand as being in the category of birchos hamitzvos—a berachah on the mitzvah of marriage,³⁰ while others view it as belonging to the category of birchos hashevach—a berachah of thanks to Hashem.³¹

Instruct the bride and groom to listen to the berachos and refrain from talking, and to answer *amen* to both berachos. Where applicable, tell them to have in mind to be yotzei the berachos,³² and to refrain from answering *baruch hu uvaruch shemo* to either berachah.

Holding a glass of wine (the same glass that will be used later for Birchas Nissuin and then broken by the groom), recite *borei pri hagafen* and Birchas Eirusin.³³ The groom and bride are then given a sip of the wine to drink.³⁴ They do not recite a berachah before drinking the wine.³⁵ Although you have made a *hagafen*, do not taste the wine yourself.³⁶

Kiddushin



Ask the witnesses if the ring is worth a perutah, and they answer in the affirmative.³⁷ This is done (1) so that the witnesses know that the groom is giving proper kiddushin; and (2) so that the bride is aware that the kiddushin is only being done with a shavet perutah, and if she will later claim that the ring is worth less than she was told, it will not affect the kiddushin.³⁸

that the relatives and other possul onlookers will not be included in the testimony (*Ketzos Hachoshen* 36:1).

Some say that since the groom specifically desires that the kiddushin be viewed by kosher witnesses, this intent itself is sufficient to exclude all possul onlookers from being considered witnesses, even if the kosher witnesses were not singled out (see *Avnei Milu'im* 42:6).

Accordingly, if the mesader kiddushin designated two kosher witnesses but did not single them out aloud, the kiddushin is still valid (*Avnei Milu'im* *ibid.*).

30 *Rambam, Ishus* 3:23.

31 *Rosh, Kesubos* 1:12.

32 *Siddur Derech Hachaim* ch. 244.

33 Although the berachah relates to the marriage, it is recited by the mesader kiddushin and not by the groom himself. One reason for this is to prevent the embarrassment of a groom who does not know how to recite the berachah (*Rama, Even Ha'ezer* 34:1 and *Beis Shmuel* *ad loc.*).

Ten male Jews must be present when the berachah is recited. The groom may be counted as one of the ten (*Shulchan Aruch, Even Ha'ezer* 34:4). However, unlike birchas nissuin, *bedi'eved* if there is no minyan it may still be recited (*Beis Shmuel* *ad loc.*). Nowadays, when the eirusin and nissuin take place one after the next, it is unusual to have a minyan for the nissuin but not for the eirusin. If there is no complete minyan to begin with, a rov should be consulted.

34 *Siddur Admor Hazaken*.

35 *Ezer Mikodesh* 34:2.

36 See *Heichal Menachem* vol. 3, p. 176.

37 *Rama, Even Ha'ezer* 31:2.

38 *Rama, Even Ha'ezer* 31:2.



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Using his right hand, the groom places the ring on the bride's right index finger.³⁹ If the groom is left-handed, he should use his left hand. If the bride is left-handed, however, the ring should still be placed on her right index finger, unless she usually wears rings on her left hand.⁴⁰

As he begins to place the ring, the groom says "הרי את מקודשת לי בטבעת זו" כדת משה וישראל," securing it on her finger as he says the last word, *v'yisrael*.⁴² If the groom and/or bride do not understand Hebrew, he should recite the translation of these words in a language they understand, in addition to saying the phrase in Hebrew.⁴³

The witnesses must clearly see the groom place the ring on the bride's finger⁴⁴ and must hear him say *harei at*.⁴⁵ Care should be taken to ensure that their view is not obstructed by photographers, the page with the berachos, etc.

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39 *Shu"t Maharam Mintz* 109, cited in *Ba'er Hetev, Even Ha'ezer* 27:1. For a reason why the index finger is used, see *Igros Kodosh* vol. 3, p. 429 citing from *Taamei Haminhagim* p. 412.

The kiddushin is valid if the left hand (of either the groom or bride) was used, or if the ring was placed on a different finger.

40 *Shu"t Be'er Moshe* 2:62.

41 It should be noted that the correct pronunciation of this word is zo with a cholam (and not zu with a shuruk), as it appears in the Alter Rebbe's siddur.

42 *Toras Menachem* vol. 10, p. 200.

43 The kiddushin is valid even if he only said these words in Hebrew, as long as he knows they are an expression of kiddushin (*Tiv Kiddushin* 27:10).

44 "Assumptions are insufficient" (*Rama, Even Ha'ezer* 42:4).

45 *Otzar Haposkim* 42:32:19.